administration had imposed Section 144—prohibiting public gathering—and shut down internet services.

On February 12, seeing that the battle of perception was being lost, the Bengal government formed a 10-member police fact-finding team to probe the allegations. A hitherto silent West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee also spoke up. "Our state women's commission team has visited the area and a report has been submitted to me. The police have arrested the people the locals were angry with and those who instigated the violence," she said. The same day, Governor C.V. Ananda Bose visited Sandeshkhali, and later said that he was "shaken by the situation".



ANI

Leader of the opposition, BJP's Suvendu Adhikari (above), has vowed to lead a march into Sandeshkhali in a few days

On February 13, a fact-finding team headed by DIG Soma Das Mitra visited Sandeshkhali and spoke to 60 women. Hossain Mehedi Rehman, the superintendent of police of the Basirhat police district, said they have received four written complaints from the protesters. However, a source in the team says: "We received all sorts of complaints, from land grab to physical assault of the men and molestation of women." However, this officer also says that no one gave a first-hand account of women being raped. "We understand there is social and personal stigma or even fear of goons, hence many might not be willing to speak up. We are trying to build their confidence," he says, adding that most of the women the team spoke to were TMC supporters.

The Opposition has alleged that villagers are being pressured and warned against speaking to the police or journalists. However, tales of terror are not far beneath the surface. "We were called to attend so-called meetings late in the night. Only women were called," says a complainant. "The only men were Shahjahan, Sibu, Uttam and their men. We were taunted and touched inappropriately. We switched off our phones out of fear."

The TMC, though, sees the whole matter as a brainchild of the Opposition. It is still not unclear if the protests were a planned move or a spontaneous outburst by the marginalised, although some sources suggest that the BJP and the CPI(M) have stoked the unrest. Some also hint that TMC men who had been sidelined by the growing clout of Shahjahan saw an opportunity in the muscleman's physical absence and aided the spiraling protests. "Shahjahan's power grew after the 2013 panchayat polls and he has since become the don of the area. The uprising against him has happened 10 years later, and at a time when he is absconding and at his weakest," says a TMC source.

State irrigation minister Partha Bhowmick and other TMC leaders also went to meet the aggrieved women of Sandeshkhali on January 13. Bhowmick claims that he heard no allegations of molestation. "Many people complained that their fish ponds were taken on lease and payments were not being made. I promised them that all the due lease payments will be cleared by the party," he said. Earlier, Bhowmick had also said that the party had got no complaints against Shahjahan. Shahjahan, Uttam and Sibu were members of the TMC-run local zilla parishad.

The BJP has now moved the Calcutta High Court against the police allowing the TMC contingent to visit Sandeshkhali, when others were denied permission on the pretext of Section 144. Even as Justice Jay Sengupta of the Calcutta HC overruled the order imposing Section 144 across Sandeshkhali on February 13, a clash took place between BJP protesters marching towards SP Rehman's office. Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari and other BJP MLAs were also stopped from visiting Sandeshkhali on February 12. Adhikari announced that another march to the village would be made soon.

Clearly, the BJP is trying to turn Sandeshkhali into the TMC's Achilles' heel, just as Nandigram and Singur were for the Left regime. On February 12, Union minister Smriti Irani addressed the media on the issue at the BJP headquarters in Delhi. "Who is this man who has been charged of the mass rape of Bengali Hindu women in Sandeshkhali?.... Mamata Banerjee has to answer the question, where is Sheikh Shahjahan?" she said.

Meanwhile, the TMC has announced that it will hold a public meeting in Sandeshkhali on February 18 and is brazening it out elsewhere. "We must check the veracity of the allegations. The CPI(M) and the BJP are trying to instigate people," maintains state general secretary Kunal Ghosh. ■